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Aesthetics
Dr. Hay
May 22, 2026

Event Description

On Saturday, May 17, 2026, Kevin Olusola performed at Cochran Chapel at Phillips Academy Andover. Olusola is a cellist and beatboxer, and he is probably best known as a member of Pentatonix. The concert was open to the school community and lasted about an hour and a half. He performed solo pieces where he played the cello and beatboxed at the same time, which is what he is most known for. At a few points, he also brought groups on stage with him, first the school choir, then members of the chamber orchestra. By the end of the performance, everyone was standing and cheering.

I do not usually go to live music performances, and I do not have a background in classical music. I mostly knew Olusola from YouTube videos and performances with Pentatonix, so I thought I knew what to expect before going.

Discussion

I ended up being wrong about that. Watching him perform live felt completely different from watching videos online. The sound was louder and more physical than I expected, and seeing everything happen right in front of me actually made it harder to understand how he was doing it. In a video, you can watch it once and move on. In person, I kept staring and trying to figure out how he could play cello and beatbox at the same time (I can't focus on two things at the same time).

That difference between the live performance and the video version reminded me of something from the Benjamin reading. Benjamin explains that reproductions of art always lose something, which he calls the "aura." He means that the original work exists in a specific place and time, and that feeling of presence cannot really be copied. Before this concert, I mostly understood that idea in a very abstract way, especially for paintings or museums. But during this performance, I understood it more clearly. The videos of Olusola online are accurate, they show exactly what he does, but they do not capture the feeling of actually being there in the room while it happens. The live performance felt unique because it was happening once in that exact moment, and it could never happen in exactly the same way again with the energy from him and the crowd.

Another thing that stood out to me was how unusual his skill set is. Cello and beatboxing are not things that are normally combined. There is not really a tradition or standard way of learning how to do what he does. Instead, it feels like he created it himself by experimenting with ideas that interested him until they worked. This connects to Kant's idea of genius from the readings. Kant argues that genius is not just following rules that already exist. Instead, genius creates something original that cannot simply be taught through instruction. That idea seemed true while

watching Olusola perform. Someone could probably learn cello and beatboxing separately, but the way he combines them into one performance style feels completely personal and unique to him.

The part of the concert that surprised me most was when he brought the choir on stage. These were students from school, people I see every day, but when they started singing with him, the atmosphere in the room changed. I cannot fully explain why. Part of it was probably the surprise of seeing classmates become part of the performance. But I also think it was because the concert stopped feeling like something we were just watching and started feeling like something everyone in the room was experiencing together (almost like interacting in a sense). I have gone to many school events where I mostly felt like an observer (like ASM). This performance felt different, and I think that was because the crowd was in awe of Olusola, but also proud of PA students for keeping up with him and showcasing their own genius. Everyone in the chapel was sharing the same moment, and it could not be replayed or repeated. I think in the future I will try to go to more live concerts and performances as this one was a positive experience. To me, life is always passing around us. If we never truly take the time to stop and appreciate the moment, and to appreciate the genius of others, we will truly never be fulfilled. The aura felt by that performance was something I don't think I can capture again in my lifetime, as it was unique to the moment.

Benjamin, Walter. "The Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction." *Illuminations*, translated by Harry Zohn, Schocken Books, 1955, pp. 218-224.

Immanuel Kant. "Judgments About the Beautiful." *Aesthetics: A Reader in Philosophy of the Arts*, edited by David Goldblatt, Lee B. Brown, and Stephanie Patridge, 4th ed., Routledge, pp. 490-495.

Kevin Olusola. Performance. Cochran Chapel, Phillips Academy Andover, Andover, MA, 17 May 2026.